FARAH AKHTAR

BBA | MBA | PhD (Economics) | Quantitative Researcher | Higher Education Professional

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PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Quantitative researcher and higher-education administration professional with a PhD in Economics (Universiti Tunku Abdul Rahman) specializing in structural equation modeling (PLS-SEM) and ESG / digital-transformation research on SME financial performance. Author of five publications (one corresponding, three first-author) and recipient of a Best Paper Award (BAFE 2024). Combines advanced statistical modeling (SmartPLS, SPSS, STATA, EViews) with five years of academic administration, teaching, and thesis-defense coordination experience, plus prior banking and customer-relations experience.

TEACHING SUBJECT AREAS

Economics, Microeconomics, Macroeconomics, International Economics, Statistics, Research Methods and Academic Writing, Management and Human Resource Management.

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Digital transformation, ESG practices, and financial performance among SMEs, using PLS-SEM, situated within Resource-Based View, Dynamic Capabilities Theory, and Institutional Theory. Currently extending this line of work into a cross-country study of SME reputation and performance across Malaysia and Pakistan.

EDUCATION

PhD in Economics | Universiti Tunku Abdul Rahman (UTAR), Teh Hong Piow Faculty of Business and Finance *2023 – 2026*

• Thesis: "Unlocking Growth and Sustainability: The Impact of Digital Transformation and ESG on Financial Performance." Supervisors: Prof. Dr. Abdelhak Senadjki (Main); Dr. Vikniswari Vija Kumaran (Co-Supervisor).

Master of Business Administration (MBA), Human Resource Management | SZABIST, Karachi, Pakistan *2016 – 2018*

• CGPA 3.58, Merit, Chancellor's Honor Roll

Bachelor of Business Administration (BBA), Human Resource Management | SZABIST, Karachi, Pakistan *2011 – 2015*

• First-Class Honours

PEER-REVIEWED PUBLICATIONS

• Bashir, M.J.K., Senadjki, A., Salah, W.A., Abuhelwa, M., & Akhtar, F. (2026). Decentralized solar energy utilisation: evaluating behavioral drivers and environmental awareness in the economically challenged territories. International Journal of Energy and Water Resources, 10, 96. Springer. Corresponding author; Scopus Q3.

• Akhtar, F., Senadjki, A., & Vija Kumaran, V. (2025). Sustainability meets digital culture: the influence of ESG on financial performance in Malaysian manufacturing SMEs. Journal of Innovative Digital Transformation, 2(1), 90–108. Emerald. First author.

• Akhtar, F., Senadjki, A., & Vija Kumaran, V. (2025). Mapping the Underlying Factors of Firms' Economic Performance: Antecedents of Digital Transformation and ESG Reporting. Malaysian Journal of Social Sciences and Humanities, 10(10), e003642. First author.

• Akhtar, F., Senadjki, A., & Kumaran, V.V. (2025). Navigating the Digital Era: Role of Intellectual Capital. 12th BAFE 2024 Proceedings, Springer Nature. First author; presenting author; Best Paper Award.

• Akhtar, F., Senadjki, A., & Kumaran, V.V. (2023). Unearthing the Nexus between ESG and Financial Performance: Does Company Size and Age Matter? 11th BAFE 2023 Proceedings, Atlantis Press. First author; presenting author.

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

• BAFE 2024, 23 October 2024 — Best Paper Award, presenting author
• UTAR-UMSIDA Forum, "Sustainability in the Digital Economy," THP FBF, 28 August 2024, presenting author
• BAFE 2023, 25 October 2023, presenting author

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Visiting Faculty, Computer Science Department | SZABIST, Larkana, Pakistan *Oct 2020 – Feb 2021*

• CSC4603 Management Principles — Fall 2020 learner evaluation: 99.45%

Visiting Faculty, Management Sciences Department | SZABIST, Larkana, Pakistan *Feb 2019 – Jun 2019*

• BA1109 Personal Management and Communication — Spring 2019 learner evaluation: 96.49%

RESEARCH & ACADEMIC EXPERIENCE

Researcher | Department of Economics, THP FBF, UTAR, Malaysia *2024 – 2026*

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Academics & Records Officer | SZABIST, Larkana, Pakistan *Aug 2017 – Apr 2022*

• Coordinated semester schedules and Academic Calendars; administered institutional academic data and reporting via the ZABDESK ERP student records system.
• Organized Thesis and Dissertation Defense sessions and managed manuscript dispatch to evaluators, ensuring full procedural compliance.
• Conducted semester-wise structured teacher evaluations and presented findings to the Head of Campus.
• Maintained Faculty Digital Attendance Registers across BBA, MBA, and BSCS programs; supplied monthly financial data to Finance for faculty payments.
• Coordinated course registration and student enrolment workflows each semester; supervised operational support staff.

Personal Banking Officer (O.G IV) | Summit Bank Limited, Sales & Liabilities Dept. *Apr 2016 – Aug 2017*

• Managed end-to-end account opening/closing in compliance with bank policy and regulatory standards.
• Built trust-based customer relationships and identified cross-selling opportunities, contributing to branch customer-base growth.

Internships | Pakistan International Airlines (HR Services, Summer 2015); Askari Commercial Bank, Larkana (Accounts & Problem Resolution, Summer 2013)

PEER REVIEW SERVICE

Three completed reviews plus one invited.

• Pertanika Journal of Tropical Agricultural Science (Scopus; WoS ESCI Q3) — completed
• Journal of Tropical Resources and Sustainable Science (Scopus) — completed
• Discover Sustainability (Springer Nature) — ongoing reviewer service
• SN Business & Economics (Springer Nature) — invited, in progress

AWARDS & SCHOLARSHIPS

• Best Paper Award, BAFE 2024
• Chancellor's Honor Roll, MBA
• UTAR Research Scholarship Scheme (RSS), via Institute of Postgraduate Studies and Research (IPSR), 2023 – 2026 — competitive merit-based doctoral research scholarship

SERVICE

• Postgraduate Representative, UTAR Students' Representative Council, Kampar, 2024/2025
• BAFE Publicity and Promotion Committee (2025)
• BAFE Proceedings Support Committee (2024)
• Emcee, UTAR R&D Colloquium (2025)
• Emcee, "Lessons from the Alumni" (2026)
• Emcee, Department of Economics guest session, Relational Strategies for Career Success, UTAR (2024)

CERTIFICATIONS & PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT

• CB-SEM using SmartPLS 4 — Prof. James Gaskin, Bahçeşehir Cyprus University (30 Jan 2024)
• Scopus Platform Training — Elsevier at UTAR (8 Aug 2024)
• Excellence in Peer Review — Taylor & Francis (13 Nov 2024)
• Choosing Quality Journals — Taylor & Francis (20 Nov 2024)
• Publishing Ethics 101 — Taylor & Francis (9 Apr 2025)
• Avoiding Predatory Publishing — Taylor & Francis (21 May 2025)
• How to Select a Journal & Publish Effectively with Emerald — Emerald East Asia at UTAR (20 Nov 2025)
• Open Access Publishing Success — Wiley (25 Nov 2025)
• Research Writing Workshop — CAP & Master of Psychology (I/O), UTAR (28–29 Oct 2023)

TECHNICAL & RESEARCH SKILLS

• SEM & Statistics: SmartPLS 4 (PLS-SEM, IPMA, PLSpredict), AMOS 28 (CB-SEM), R (lavaan, semTools), SPSS v29, STATA 17, EViews
• Qualitative Tools: NVivo 14, ATLAS.ti
• Data & Reporting: Microsoft Power BI, Tableau, Excel (Advanced: Pivot Tables, Power Query), SQL (PostgreSQL)
• Research Tools: LaTeX, EndNote 21, Mendeley, Scopus, ZABDESK

LANGUAGES

English (Professional), Urdu (Professional), Sindhi (Native), Punjabi (Conversational), spoken Hindi

REFERENCES

Available upon request.